Paul Kiernan

Staff+ Infrastructure Engineer — Search, Retrieval & Streaming Systems

San Francisco, CA • hi@paulynomial.com • paulynomial.com • github.com/paulkiernan • linkedin.com/in/paulynomial • 646.369.6726

SUMMARY

Fifteen years in large-scale distributed systems. Tech lead for the search indexing and Kafka streaming platform behind Reddit (500M+ monthly users): a multi-billion-document Solr/Lucene index, a 5M+ messages/sec event backbone, and the retrieval systems that later served Reddit's LLM products. Founding engineer turned CTO of an AI document-redaction platform (SOC 2 Type II, multi-region AWS, 10M+ documents for the NHS and others). Inventor on US Patent 10,068,250. Seeking principal-level ownership of retrieval and streaming infrastructure for the LLM era.

EXPERIENCE

Independent Work — San Francisco, CA — Nov 2025 – Present

- Exploring what indexing and retrieval infrastructure look like when agents, not humans, are the query interface. **[FILL: link to write-up]**
- **[FILL: Artifact 1, e.g. the self-hosted agent execution platform: name, one-line description, link]**
- **[FILL: Artifact 2, e.g. the MCP proxy work: name, one-line description, link]**

Phaselaw — Remote (San Francisco, CA) — Jul 2023 – Nov 2025

Chief Technology Officer — Oct 2024 – Nov 2025

- Led engineering for an AI-powered document review and redaction platform handling highly sensitive legal and personal data: 10M+ documents redacted for the NHS, the UK Labour Party, and the Raspberry Pi Foundation. **[FILL: business outcome — ARR or customer growth, fundraise closed, or contracts won]**
- Built and led the engineering organization **[FILL: from N to M engineers]**; owned hiring, engineering culture, and technical due diligence with investors and partners.
- Took the platform through SOC 2 Type II: CI/CD, automated testing, OpenTelemetry observability, and multi-region Terraform on AWS (US, EU, and UK for data residency); stack: LLM-based PII identification (Claude on AWS Bedrock), Temporal orchestration, multi-tenant Kubernetes with ArgoCD GitOps.

Founding Backend Engineer — Jul 2023 – Oct 2024

- Designed and built the core backend from zero (data models, API layer, authn/authz, service architecture) across multiple global regions; made the foundational technology choices, favoring boring, proven technology so a **[FILL: N]**-person team could ship and operate a global platform.

Reddit — San Francisco, CA — Jul 2018 – Jul 2023

Staff Software Engineer, Search & Data Engineering — Nov 2019 – Jul 2023

- Tech lead for search indexing: managed 3 engineers and mentored 3 more while staying hands-on. Owned end-to-end design of the Scala/Apache Flink pipeline keeping a multi-billion-document Solr/Lucene index fresh against millions of events per second.
- The same indexing and retrieval systems later served all of Reddit's LLM applications. **[FILL: name them, e.g. Reddit Answers, and any data-licensing corpora they fed]**
- Shipped comment search, a capability Reddit had lacked for a decade after post search, by architecting the Kafka infrastructure and consumer DAG that indexes 7.5M+ new comments/day within 60 seconds of posting. **[FILL: outcome — lift in search sessions, share of search traffic, or retention]**
- Designed the Kafka platform that finally scaled for Reddit: multiple self-managed clusters with tuned partitioning and replication and a new consumer-processor pattern; a 5M+ messages/sec backbone adopted by the analytics, data warehousing, and subreddit notification teams.
- Led search incident response and materially improved Reddit Search uptime. **[FILL: from X to Y, e.g. 99.5% to 99.95%]**

Senior Software Engineer II, Data Infrastructure — Jul 2018 – Nov 2019

- Replaced poll- and cron-based batch jobs with event-driven analytics and Kafka-to-BigQuery warehouse ingestion pipelines, cutting downstream latency from hours to seconds.

Chartbeat — Head of Backend Engineering — New York, NY — Aug 2014 – Jul 2018

- Led 8 backend engineers across 4 product teams; earlier led the R&D team (Backend Team Lead) and presented experimental products to the board.
- Built MrRoboto, a replicated C++ key-value store sustaining 500k+ writes/sec (LMDB copy-on-write B-tree, chain replication); Miata, a real-time streaming analytics framework on Kafka, ZeroMQ, and Python; and the probabilistic-counting backend for the "so far today" API. Open-sourced Parselmouth.

Moat (acquired by Oracle) — Software Developer — New York, NY — Jun 2012 – Aug 2014

- Early engineer on Moat Pro, an enterprise ad-intelligence platform; built the geo-distributed web-crawler network, ETL pipeline, and reporting API that detected, captured, and indexed online advertisements.

SKILLS

Languages: Python, Scala, C++, Java, C, Clojure, SQL, Shell

Systems & infrastructure: Kafka, Apache Flink, Solr/Lucene, BigQuery, Temporal, ZeroMQ, AWS (multi-region), Kubernetes, Terraform, ArgoCD, OpenTelemetry, HAProxy

AI/LLM: LLM extraction pipelines (Claude on AWS Bedrock), retrieval infrastructure for LLM applications

EDUCATION & PATENTS

Cornell University, BS in Electrical & Computer Engineering, 2012. McMullen Dean Scholar; Goldfarb Tradition Fellow.

US Patent 10,068,250, inventor: "System and method for measuring mobile advertising and content by simulating mobile-device usage" — **[FILL: one clause on what it covers]**